



Become one with WinSCP and PuTTY

If you have your own Web site, WinSCP is an indispensable for secure FTP access to your server

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Anyone hosting an FTP server without SSH and SCP protocols isn't secure. Whether you have a complicated 76-character password, or use specialised characters, numbers, capitalised letters, etc., it can all be rendered completely useless by nothing more than a script kiddie with a sniffer.

When not using any kind of secure protocol for transferring files, passwords are transmitted in plain text, which means anyone using a sniffer on your network can see those passwords exactly as they are, and accessing your server is simply a matter of copy-pasting from the sniffer to the password box. That's where protocols like SSH (Secure Shell) and SCP (Secure Copy) step in. Instead of sending out the passwords in plain text, SSH encrypts any password you send out, thus showing a jumble of gibberish to anyone sniffing the network, while SCP encrypts the actual file transfers that take place making them unrecoverable for any sniffers.

Now if you have SSH and SCP on your server, you will need to have clients to connect to them. The two most popular are PuTTY and WinSCP. Anyone who knows what SSH is has probably already used PuTTY to remote connect to servers. It is similar to a Telnet client, but obviously more secure. WinSCP is one of the best SCP programs out there, and offers the ability to edit files in real-time directly on the server, thus saving you the time required to download, edit and upload again. We'll look at WinSCP version 3.8.2 and PuTTY version 0.59 for this article.

Integrate PuTTY With WinSCP

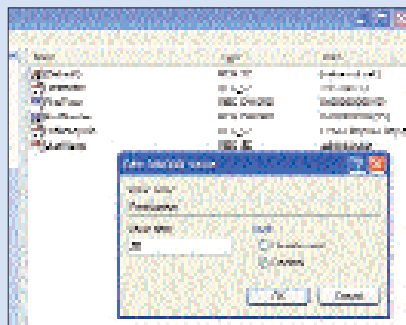
Getting straight down to business, the first thing you should do is directly integrate WinSCP with PuTTY. After you connect to a server, go to **Options > Preferences** and click on **Integration**. Here click on the text box entitled 'PuTTY Path' and enter the path to the putty.exe file. You should now be able to fire up PuTTY whenever required by using the [Ctrl] + [P] key combination. Instead of just

starting PuTTY, WinSCP will directly open the server you are on, and enter the username and password for you.

Default Session Settings

When you start WinSCP, you find that you have to input a server, username and password. If all you do is use WinSCP to access a single server, you can stop this time-wasting. You can use "Stored Sessions" to remember your username and password for a particular server, and this will save you a lot of time.

If you want to save even more time, and have WinSCP open with the server address, username and port already entered, you can change it's default settings. Open the registry editor (**Start > Run > regedit**) and navigate to **HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Martin Prikryl\WinSCP 2\Sessions\Default%20Settings**. In the right pane, right-click and select **New > String Value**, name it **HostName** and give it a value of the server's IP. Create another String value called **UserName** and give it the value of the username. If your connection port is not 22, you can set the default port number here by creating a **DWORD** value called **PortNumber** and giving it a decimal value of the port you want to connect to. Be careful here because hexadecimal and decimal values differ. Passwords cannot be stored, but it's a lot easier than typing everything, and

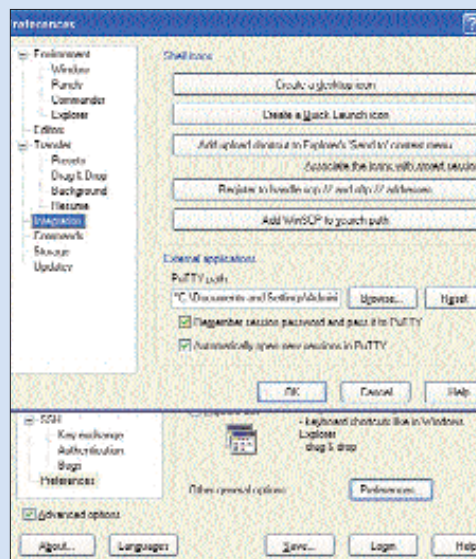


Make sure to enter the port number in the decimal format

besides, you shouldn't store passwords—for security purposes.

Sharing Between WinSCP And PuTTY

So your logon settings are saved in WinSCP, including usernames and passwords, but what about PuTTY? You can export your WinSCP setting to PuTTY by starting WinSCP and going to **Preferences** in the left hand pane. Now you will see a button called **Preferences**, click on it and then click



Don't forget to enter the path to your putty.exe

on **Integration** and tick the "Remember session password and pass it to PuTTY" checkbox. This will let you open PuTTY with the session name "WinSCP Temporary Session" whenever you choose to do so.

Change The Default Name

Taking the previous tip further, if you don't like the "WinSCP Temporary Session" title when you open PuTTY, change it.

Just open the registry editor, navigate to the key **HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Martin Prikryl\WinSCP 2\Configuration\Interface**, find the String value called "PuttySession", double-click on it and give it any name you want. Just remember to put "%20" (without quotes) instead of spaces.